



All smiles: Actor and owner of the NorthEast United FC (NEUFC), John Abraham, celebrates with coach Juan Pedro Benali after their team won the Durand Cup 2024. PTI

John embraced coach Juan Pedro Benali, the mastermind behind the triumph, while celebrating alongside the players and coaching staff.

"The feeling of winning the Durand Cup has not yet sunk in. This is just a lesson for all to never give up, to hold on to the team and support the team, not just in winning times but even when we are losing," John reflected.

Although the victory came later than expected, it must have brought him the long-awaited joy he had sought since pooling his resources into the franchise in 2014. His investment seemed to stem from a desire to fulfill his unachieved dream of playing for his country. John was also drawn to the unique distinction of owning a club that represents an entire region — the eight

NorthEastern states — rather than just a single city or state.

"It is a proud moment for all of us at the football club. It is the first trophy the club has won, and we would like to dedicate this trophy to all our fans," said the club's CEO, Mandar Tamhane. "We are a club that represents eight states, not just one state or one city. It's a big responsibility for us when we represent our fans. This victory is for the fans; they deserve it for supporting the club through highs and lows. It's the first victory, and it's very special."

The arrival of Benali in 2023 provided NorthEast United with the right tactician to build a team capable of competing against the giants of Indian football. Before this, the club's best performance had been reaching the ISL playoffs twice, once in the 2018-2019 season under Dutch coach Eelco Schattorie and then in 2020-21 under Khalid Jamil. The club has been plagued by frequent changes at the top, with Benali being the 12th coach

in 10 seasons. During this time, the team has undergone 14 coaching changes, with Jamil stepping in on three occasions.

Roughly three seasons after its formation, NorthEast United FC had launched its first youth development initiative in partnership with Shillong United FC, unveiling the Centre of Excellence (CoE). This programme was designed to scout talent from the region and provide year-round training, education, and competition. However, the initiative fizzled out due to various challenges. The club later acknowledged its failure to sustain talent development efforts over the years and launched a second initiative this year to revive the tradition of scouting young players from the NorthEast.

Among the club's local talents is Parthib Gogoi, a promising young forward selected by coach Benali last season. Gogoi, who began his career with the AIFF developmental side Indian Arrows, is progressing well. He had one goal and one assist in this